

The Jobs-to-be-Done Framework: Understanding Customer Needs

Products succeed when they reliably do a "job" for customers, a more crucial factor than merely having best-in-class features.

Key Takeaways

- Customers "hire" products to accomplish specific jobs they need done, not primarily for their abstract features.
- A product's true competition includes anything that also helps customers get the same job done, even the option of doing nothing.
- New features are only valuable if they genuinely help customers complete their job better, faster, or more reliably.
- Effective customer research involves asking about the last time they tried to "hire" something for a job, rather than their preferences.
- The core job a product fulfills should be describable in a single, verb-led sentence to clarify its purpose.

Apply the Jobs-to-be-Done Framework This Week

Action Items

- Pick one of your products or services and, this week, draft its core "job-to-be-done" statement starting with a verb.
- Identify three unexpected competitors for that product or service that also solve the core job for customers.
- Interview one customer next week about the last time they "hired" your product to do a specific job, focusing on their journey.
- Review your product roadmap and evaluate if new features genuinely improve the core job completion.

Decisions to Make

- Should we re-evaluate our product's core purpose based on the "job-to-be-done" framework, or maintain our current feature-centric view?
- How will we shift our customer research methodology to focus more on understanding "jobs" rather than just abstract preferences?

Questions to Explore

- How can we effectively communicate our product's "job-to-be-done" to internal teams and external customers?

- What are the specific challenges in transitioning an existing product team from a feature-driven to a job-driven mindset?
- Are there specific metrics we can track to measure how well our product performs its stated "job-to-be-done" for customers?